

Herpes Simplex Virus (HSV) – Summary

Key Symptoms:

- **Primary infection:** asymptomatic or primary HSV gingivostomatitis → fever, malaise, etc.
- **Subsequent infections:** cold sores
- **Sites of infection:** oral, genital, ocular, nervous system

Most common causative pathogens: HSV-1 (primary cause of herpes labialis) and HSV-2 (primary cause of genital herpes)

Triggers for Reactivation: Stress, infection, immunosuppression, menstruation, sunlight, etc.

Non-Pharmacological Treatment:

- Gently clean area with mild soap & water, cool or warm compresses, sunscreen (particularly if triggered by sunlight)
- **Topical protectants for cold sores:** petrolatum, cocoa butter, calamine lotion, etc.
- Frequent hand washing, avoid touching area

Pharmacological Treatment:

- **Non-Prescription Products:**
 - Docosanol cream (Abreva®) (if applied at the first sign of recurrence, may shorten time to healing by ~ 1-3 days)
 - Oral acetaminophen or NSAIDs for moderate-severe pain
 - Topical benzocaine, lidocaine/prilocaine, camphor, etc. for mild pain
- **Prescription products:**
 - **Herpes Labialis and/or Genital Herpes:** acyclovir **OR** famciclovir **OR** valacyclovir
 - **HSV encephalopathy:** acyclovir IV
 - **HSV meningitis:** acyclovir PO

Additional Key Points:

- It may take approx. 1-2 weeks for cold sores to fully resolve
- There is no cure for HSV, it stays in the ganglia lifelong and can reactivate at any time
- Pts should be referred to a doctor if they are immunocompromised, present with ≥ 6 recurrences/year, symptoms last > 2 weeks or if signs of a secondary bacterial infection
- In primary genital infections, viral shedding lasts on average 12 days, and lesions heal on average between 2-4 weeks
- In recurrent genital infections, viral shedding lasts on average 4 days, and lesions heal on average in 7-10 days